

STUDENT HANDOUT

Making Something New

Grades 3–4

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Critical Frame: The Harlem Renaissance was not just a cultural flourishing — it was a deliberate intellectual and political project. W.E.B. Du Bois argued that Black artists should use their work to advance civil rights. Alain Locke called for a "New Negro" — defined not by oppression but by creative achievement. The art was an argument.

ACTIVITY 1 · COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

Two voices, one argument

Choose one pairing below. Research both figures using books, the exhibition, or reliable online sources.

Aaron Douglas + Langston Hughes | Duke Ellington + Zora Neale Hurston | Bessie Smith + Jacob Lawrence

Pairing I chose: _____

ARTIST / CREATOR 1

Name: _____

Creative form: _____

Central argument or theme:

_____

_____

Key technique or style choice:

_____

ARTIST / CREATOR 2

Name: _____

Creative form: _____

Central argument or theme:

_____

_____

Key technique or style choice:

_____

What do both have in common, despite their different forms?

_____

_____

ACTIVITY 2 · CRITICAL RESPONSE

Which voice is more powerful — and why?

This is a question without a right answer. Write your genuine opinion, backed by specific evidence from your research. Aim for 5–7 sentences.

ACTIVITY 3

The bigger claim

W.E.B. Du Bois believed that art could do what politics alone could not — change how people feel about each other, not just what laws said. Do you agree? Use an example from the Harlem Renaissance and one from today to support your view.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Deep dive: In the exhibition, compare the electric phonograph (sound) with the Harlem in Words poetry workshop (language). Both communicate — but how differently? What can music do that words can't, and vice versa?

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Family research project: Together, look up one piece of Harlem Renaissance art online — a painting, a poem, or a song. Discuss: What is this saying? Who was it made for? Does it still speak to you today?